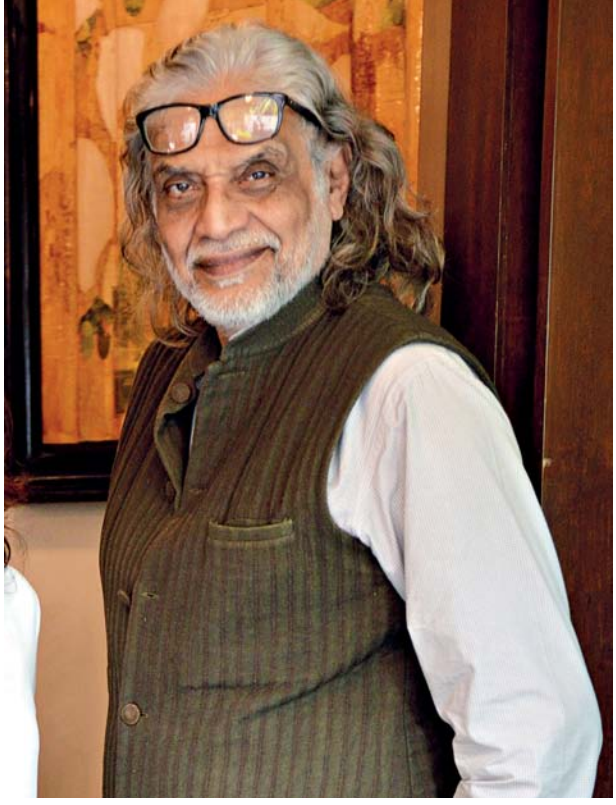


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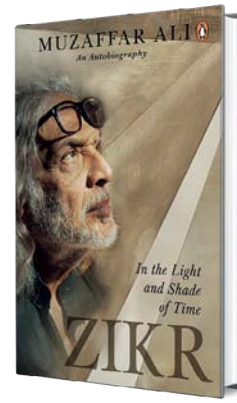
BOOKS

THE EXTRA MILE

IN **MUZAFFAR ALI'S** MEMOIR, WE SEE THE SUM OF HIS MANY CREATIVE PURSUITS

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Muzaffar Ali is a man of many arts. He paints, makes films and runs a fashion house. He also stages music and dance shows and is an aficionado of Urdu poetry. "Everything is connected," he says. "If you don't know poetry, you won't know music. If you don't know either, you don't know dance. And if you don't know body language, you won't know the moving image." Now, with *Zikr: In the Light & Shade of Time*, he wears another hat—that of an author. Perhaps best known for his film *Umrao Jaan* (1981), Ali made use of Covid-19 restrictions to pen the story of his life. Entrenched in Awadh's Ganga-Jamuni *tehzeeb*, Ali's days have, in a sense, brimmed with creative journeys, but the polymath is not in the habit of imparting words of wisdom.



ZIKR: IN THE LIGHT & SHADE OF TIME
by Muzaffar Ali
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"Like many other things I write about here, I don't recommend that anyone do this," he writes. Instead, he lets poets be the experts, the voices of both beauty and intellect. By quoting them seamlessly, Ali makes his case for a more "poetry-driven" country. Be it Faiz Ahmed Faiz, one of his biggest inspirations, or Shahryar, his most frequent collaborator, the book makes one appreciate often unread verse. "These poets made me who I am," he says. "They were, at different points of time, a part of my being, and in different times, have explained life to me."

Apart from poets, another life coach was Ali's father, Raja S. Sajid Hussain of Kotwara. He had packed him off to Aligarh to study and get rid of the "feudal fragrance" he was raised in. The chapter Ali dedicates to Aligarh in *Zikr* is altogether lovely. The city "moved me to feel and think", writes Ali as he documents the beginning of his love affair with poetry, and packs in many delightful anecdotes. He says, "If you step into Aligarh and don't see a whole *pitaara* [trove] of humour, you may as well walk out of it. It's a strain of humour which has helped me in my daily life." In *Zikr*, Ali also takes us to Calcutta, where he'd work with the legend Satyajit Ray at the ad agency Clarion McCann. We see him move briefly to Delhi and finally arrive in Bombay, where he'd have an 11-year association with Air India before jumping into the world of films.

What stands out, though, is Ali's yearning for a bygone Lucknow. He writes, "The city went from a peaceful and culturally rich setting to one whose fine arts and cultural values underwent an ugly degeneration... Will we always be oblivious to the culture of sensitivity and refinement for which Lucknow has been known the world over?" Ali highlights the two Lucknows he grew up in. One reminds him of his father, for it was "intellectual and humanist", and the other he associates with his mother Kaniz Hyder for its "feminine and feudal" characteristics. Ali, notably, seems reluctant in talking about his own roles as a husband and father. He shares professional details more freely than private ones.